

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

Botswana Baylor_Botswana_2024-25_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

Baylor (formerly Baylor International Pediatric AIDS Initiative (BIPAI))

Fellowship City

Gaborone

Fellowship Country

Botswana

Fellowship Start Date

08/27/2024

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/27/2025

What is your fellowship title/role?

Project Assistant

What are your primary responsibilities?

Develop curriculum for Teen Club, a support group for 13+ year-old HIV-positive patients, and execute monthly events, on average garnering 200 attendees

Coordinate weekly tutoring sessions for children living with HIV and/or cancer

Manage and update the adolescent program database system

Plan and coordinate annual "Camp Hope" in collaboration with administrative and financial management teams

Provide editorial support on reports for presentation to donors, national government officials, and international NGOs

Screen applications, interview, and orientate volunteers for Baylor Children's Clinical Centre of Excellence.

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Disagree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

No

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.**If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**

I received a very vague overview of my role.

Describe a representative day at work.

On the weekdays, most of my work is in the office. Every given day looks very different in terms of my work. I could work on reports, coordinate an upcoming program, and update the database if we just hosted a Teen Club. I do a ton of work on Excel working on streamlining the database. On the weekends, there is either tutoring or Teen Club, so I am at the Adolescent Centre providing logistical support.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

54

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Very Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

I am responsible for the Teen Club, Tutoring Program, and Volunteer program. For Teen Club we are working on increasing retention rates within the program. To reach this, we are working on growing visibility in the clinic. We visit the clinic in the morning to meet the adolescents in the waiting room and ask them if they are a part of Teen Club and if not, whether they would like to join. This way patients know about Teen Club. We are also focused on the Volunteer Program which has been very inconsistent. Volunteers come in and out and it's been difficult to have a reliable number of volunteers. We are working on a volunteer reorientation training with the Red Cross, to engage more volunteers.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

This programming team is extremely small. The team is comprised of myself, my supervisor, and an intern. We also have two peer supporters who sporadically support us. The environment is overall positive. We are very comfortable with each other considering there are only 3 of us.

To whom do you report?

I report to the Programs Manager.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

I just jumped right into the role, that we didn't much speak about future plans.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

To create Excel formulas to ease the uploading of data, and extraction of data that is disaggregated by age, gender, etc. Another goal is to host a volunteer reorientation training in order to engage and retain more volunteers, as retention has been an issue. Thirdly, I hope to engage more patients from the clinic to join or rejoin the Teen Club.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Daily

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

At first, I didn't think I was very prepared for my responsibilities. It was all on-the-job training. However, now I feel very comfortable in my role.

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket from on Google Flights. I flew on Qatar Airways from the Los Angeles to Qatar, Qatar to Johannesburg, and Johannesburg to Gaborone. I booked a one-way ticket that cost \$957.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I believe I have an exemption.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

My organization took care of it.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

I went through the process after arriving in Gaborone.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

I'm not completely certain as I did not pay for it.

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Baylor covered them.

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Baylor makes it a very easy process and supports you through the entire process.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I needed to get an update on my TDAP vaccine. I did not get the yellow fever vaccine.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

The first week was very overwhelming since I was thrown into the job. Knowing that I will be able to onboard the next fellow and show them how to do everything is going to make the process much smoother for them.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Baylor provides a furnished and paid-for apartment near the clinic.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

I have my own apartment. My neighbors are all wonderful. It is in a gated community with round-the-clock security, so I feel very safe.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I walk to the clinic every day. It's about a 15-20 minute walk.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

I live in an urban area.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

It is currently summer so it is extremely hot.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

For work, the attire is business casual. Outside of work, people wear whatever they want. I personally choose to dress modestly as I am a hijabi.

How have you been spending your free time?

I honestly work so much I hardly have time to go out. If I get a day off I usually use it to reset and clean my apartment. Occasionally I go to the malls. I've also hosted a couple of friends at my apartment.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Disagree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I work so much that I haven't found the time to build a community and have a balanced social life.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I live in a very safe residence, with round-the-clock security. I also feel very safe at work, as there is round-the-clock security there as well.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I try to change my routes to work. I walk only on main roads, and I don't walk at night.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I haven't had any experience with crime.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

I haven't had any encounters to describe.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

I haven't changed my goals now that I am in the post. My meeting a lot of my personal goals. I think I could work on the social aspect of my experience here, and not make work my only priority.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I have no frustrations.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

No, there isn't something I haven't been able to acquire.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

The culture shock is still there. For what it's worth, I journal a lot, which has helped me adjust.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

The sheer amount of work shocked me.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The isolation and exhaustion from work have been my biggest challenges.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

I miss the temperate weather in California, I miss having a work-life balance, and I miss the variety in fast-food options.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

The food quality is incredible, especially the beef. Botswana has the most beautiful sunsets I've ever seen. The wildlife here is obviously incredible.

How is your stipend being paid?

\$850 per month.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

Wire

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

No I did not.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$-0.02	\$0.00	\$-0.02	\$9.98	\$0.00	\$-0.04
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$29.98	\$0.00	\$-0.02	\$200.00	\$-0.02	\$20.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$-0.03	\$-0.02	\$-0.02	\$0.00	0.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

The orientation was very helpful in setting intentions. I only wish that it was in person to create more of a connection with my co-fellows.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

How to balance work and social life. Ways to build community in your host countries.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office? What could we improve?

Yes I am.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

How to deal with being overworked. Self-help/care. How to set healthy boundaries.